Infection

Infection is the entry, development or multiplication of an infectious agent in the human body or animals.

22.3.3 Harmful Effects of Microbes

Pathogens cause disease in two ways. They are tissue damage and toxin secretion.

Tissue Damage: Many pathogens destroy the tissues or organs of the body causing morphological and functional damage. For example, bacterium of pulmonary tuberculosis damages the cells of the lungs, and virus causing hepatitis destroys liver tissue.

Toxin Secretion: Many pathogens secrete poisonous substances called toxins which cause tissue damage leading to diseases.

Let us now study about the causative organism, mode of infection, occurrence, symptoms and preventive measures of a few airborne, waterborne, vectorborne and sexually transmitted diseases.

DO YOU KNOW?

Robert Koch (Father of Bacteriology) is the first German physician to study how pathogens cause diseases. In 1876, he showed that the disease called anthrax of sheep was due to *Bacillus anthracis* which exist in pastures in the form of protective spores.

22.4 Airborne Diseases

Human beings inhale atmospheric air. Due to continuous inhalation of contaminated air the chances for airborne microorganisms to find a host and cause infection are higher.

Most of the respiratory tract infections are acquired by inhaling air containing the pathogen that are transmitted through droplets caused by cough or sneeze, dust and spores.

Airborne diseases are caused by bacteria and viruses. A few air borne diseases and their modes of transmission are given in the table below.

Table 22.3 Airborne diseases caused by virus

Disease	Causative Organism	Mode of Transmission	Tissue/ Organ Affected	Symptoms
Common Cold	*Rhino virus*	Droplet infection	Upper respiratory tract (Inflammation of nasal chamber)	Fever, cough, running nose, sneezing and headache
Influenza	*Myxovirus*	Droplet Infection	Respiratory tract, (Inflammation of nasal mucosa, pharynx)	Fever, body pain, cough, sore throat, nasal discharge, respiratory congestion
Measles	*Rubeola virus*	Droplet infection, droplet nuclei and direct contact with infected person	Respiratory tract	Eruption of small red spots or rashes in skin, cough, sneezing, redness of eye (conjunctiva), pneumonia, bronchitis
Mumps	*Myxovirus parotidis*	Droplet infection, droplet nuclei and direct contact with infected person	Upper respiratory tract	Enlargement of parotid gland, movement of jaw becomes difficult
Chicken Pox	*Varicella zoster virus*	Droplet infection, droplet nuclei and direct contact with infected person	Respiratory tract	Eruptions of the skin, fever and uneasiness

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